

Thanks in part to Gold's legacy of marketing to children, kids in the 1950s were the first generation to request cereal brands based on the premiums inside. Sales of Wheaties exploded in 1953 when they offered miniature license plates; and in 1969, legions of children like me demanded Cheerios for their breakfast, just because of the mail-in offer for a Super Ball. Children all over the United States were glued to the television screen, watching their favorite programs and being influenced by product sponsors. Television was an ideal forum, then and now, for sales pitches that involved children as a consumer base. Programs like *Howdy Doody* and *Andy's Gang* were closely identified with the brand that sponsored them. Ovaltine had kids mailing in labels for decoder badges, Ralston sponsored the *Tom Mix* decoder badge available in exchange for their box tops, General Mills sponsored *Lone Ranger* merchandise, and Rusty from *the Rin-Tin-Tin* show peddled other show-related premiums.

Of course, it was only a matter of time before fast-food chains wanted in on the premium rewards. Just two years after the McDonald's Happy Meal was introduced, a 1979 Star Wars-themed meal promotion included a series of comics based on the movie. Other fast-food chains mimicked that move, offering small toys with their children's meals. In 1996, McDonald's gained a major competitive advantage in the "movie tie-in premium wars" when it signed an agreement with Disney for exclusive rights to movie tie-in promotions for ten years.